Partisan Vision? Partisan Bias in Simple Visual Evaluations

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Abstract

Do partisan cues change reported counts in simple visual evaluations? Experiments in a CCES module and a Lucid survey compare error counts under Democratic and Republican cues. The clearest difference occurs among Democrats evaluating parking errors. Writing-task estimates are less precise and do not establish equivalence. An observational MTurk task shows party differences in capped mask counts, with substantial sensitivity to extreme responses. These tasks measure reported evaluations rather than visual perception directly.

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Partisan affect can shape political judgments (Iyengar et al. 2012). We examine whether attributing otherwise similar material to different parties changes reported error counts. The experimental contrast concerns party cues; it does not identify whether a response reflects perception, interpretation, effort, or expressive reporting.

1 Data and research design

The CCES files contain an unmatched sample and a smaller matched sample with team weights. Our primary estimates describe respondents in the unmatched file, retaining the original analysis population. The text task attributes a passage to Democrats or Republicans; the parking task attributes a parking lot to a party meeting. Party identification includes leaners. We retain observed outcomes and report their actual denominators. We use numeric SPSS values, not factor ranks.

Lucid replicates the writing task. We retain consenting, non-preview respondents who pass the recorded attention check. Party coding follows the original script; the supplied instrument does not document the embedded party-code mapping, so independent verification remains outstanding. The OSF registration (https://osf.io/rqj8u) is dated November 2021, after the documented 2020 CCES fieldwork. We treat it as a registered analysis description, not evidence of a prospective preregistration. It specifies uncapped outcomes, both CCES samples, party comparisons, and affective-polarization analyses. Our capping checks are exploratory; the registration does not specify cutpoints for affective polarization.

The MTurk files pool two survey waves. Respondents watched a short Trump-rally video and counted people wearing masks. The sincerity item asks how often respondents give humorous or insincere answers: never and rarely are codes 1 and 2. We retain those responses and respondents with classified party identification. This corrects an earlier reversed filter. For comparability with the original analysis, the primary descriptive outcome caps counts

at 15. This cap is an analytical choice, not a validated count of visible masks. Raw and alternatively capped results accompany the replication materials.

We report out-party minus in-party mean error counts separately for Democrats and Republicans. Positive values indicate more reported errors under the out-party cue. Welch intervals allow unequal variances; they assume independent responses and are pointwise 95% intervals. The replication tables also report Holm-adjusted p-values across the six experimental party-by-task contrasts. MTurk party differences are observational, not effects of party identification. Shared IP addresses do not establish repeat participation; a first-record-per-IP sensitivity check is reported in the replication materials.

2 Results

CCES parking, Democrat respondents: 2.63 (95% CI 1.19 to 4.06).

CCES parking, Republican respondents: 0.34 (95% CI -1.53 to 2.21).

CCES writing, Democrat respondents: 0.26 (95% CI -0.39 to 0.92).

CCES writing, Republican respondents: 0.52 (95% CI -0.33 to 1.37).

Lucid writing, Democrat respondents: 0.43 (95% CI -1.52 to 2.39).

Lucid writing, Republican respondents: 0.71 (95% CI -1.13 to 2.56).

MTurk Republican minus Democratic capped mask count: 0.87 (95% CI 0.41 to 1.33).

Table 1: Out-party minus in-party counts; Welch 95% intervals

study	task	party	estimate	lower	upper
CCES	Parking	Democrat	2.63	1.19	4.06
CCES	Parking	Republican	0.34	-1.53	2.21
CCES	Writing	Democrat	0.26	-0.39	0.92
CCES	Writing	Republican	0.52	-0.33	1.37
Lucid	Writing	Democrat	0.43	-1.52	2.39
Lucid	Writing	Republican	0.71	-1.13	2.56

Table 2: CCES Writing

party	treatment	n	mean	median	se
Democrat	Democrat	334	8.65	9.00	0.23
Democrat	Republican	324	8.92	9.00	0.24
Independent	Democrat	94	9.07	9.00	0.72
Independent	Republican	110	8.24	8.00	0.43
Republican	Democrat	252	7.59	7.00	0.34
Republican	Republican	252	7.07	7.00	0.27

Table 3: Lucid Writing

party	treatment	n	mean	median	se
Democrat	Democrat	177	5.47	5.00	0.61
Democrat	Republican	132	5.91	5.00	0.78
Independent	Democrat	73	4.56	4.00	0.30
Independent	Republican	72	5.33	5.00	0.33
Republican	Democrat	111	5.58	4.00	0.89
Republican	Republican	109	4.86	5.00	0.26

The parking contrast among Democrats is the clearest experimental result. Comparing medians alone does not show that a mean difference is caused by a handful of respondents. The accompanying sensitivity tables evaluate common response caps and the influence of deleting individual observations. The replication materials additionally report party-by-cue interactions and continuous affective-polarization moderation, using HC3 standard errors in both the unmatched and matched weighted CCES samples. Affective polarization is the pre-election in-party minus out-party thermometer score. Continuous moderation is an exploratory operationalization because the registration supplies no subgroup cutpoints; weighted-model intervals treat team weights as fixed and do not recover undocumented survey-design uncertainty.

The smaller writing-task point estimates have intervals that include both zero and substantively nonzero differences. Without a prespecified equivalence margin, these findings do not establish that partisan bias is absent or generally small.

Mask-count conclusions depend on the outcome definition. With uncapped responses,

Table 4: CCES Parking

party	treatment	n	mean	median	se
Democrat	Democrat	211	6.09	5.00	0.42
Democrat	Republican	212	8.72	6.00	0.60
Independent	Democrat	57	10.88	7.00	1.48
Independent	Republican	61	6.67	5.00	0.92
Republican	Democrat	181	8.43	6.00	0.63
Republican	Republican	163	8.09	5.00	0.71

Table 5: Mask counts capped at 15; never or rarely insincere

party	n	mean	median	se
Democrat	682	3.48	2.00	0.14
Independent	96	3.51	3.00	0.30
Republican	514	4.35	3.00	0.19

extreme values dominate the party means and reverse the estimated direction relative to the capped analysis. The capped outcome describes bounded reports; it does not recover an independently verified number of masks. The paper therefore makes no general claim of equal visual perception across parties.

3 Interpretation and limitations

These surveys measure reported counts under particular prompts. Random assignment of cues supports an interpretation as cue effects within the analyzed experimental samples, subject to outcome observation and the stated sample restrictions. Neither survey representativeness nor a perceptual mechanism follows from random assignment. The matched CCES file and its team-weighted means are reported separately because both sample selection and weighting change the population being summarized.

The replication materials document corrections, sample counts, missingness, sensitivity analyses, and remaining evidence gaps. Unavailable assignment logs, the retrospective timing of the registration, and the undocumented Lucid party codes limit verification. Inde-

pendent respondents are the inferential unit; repeated identities across MTurk waves cannot be ruled out from distinct response IDs alone. No treatment-on-treated effect, mediation mechanism, or national-population effect is identified here.

References

Shanto Iyengar, Gaurav Sood, and Yphtach Lelkes. Affect, not ideology: A social identity perspective on polarization. *Public Opinion Quarterly*, 76(3):405–431, 2012.

SI 1 Treatments

Figure SI 1.1: Text Treatment

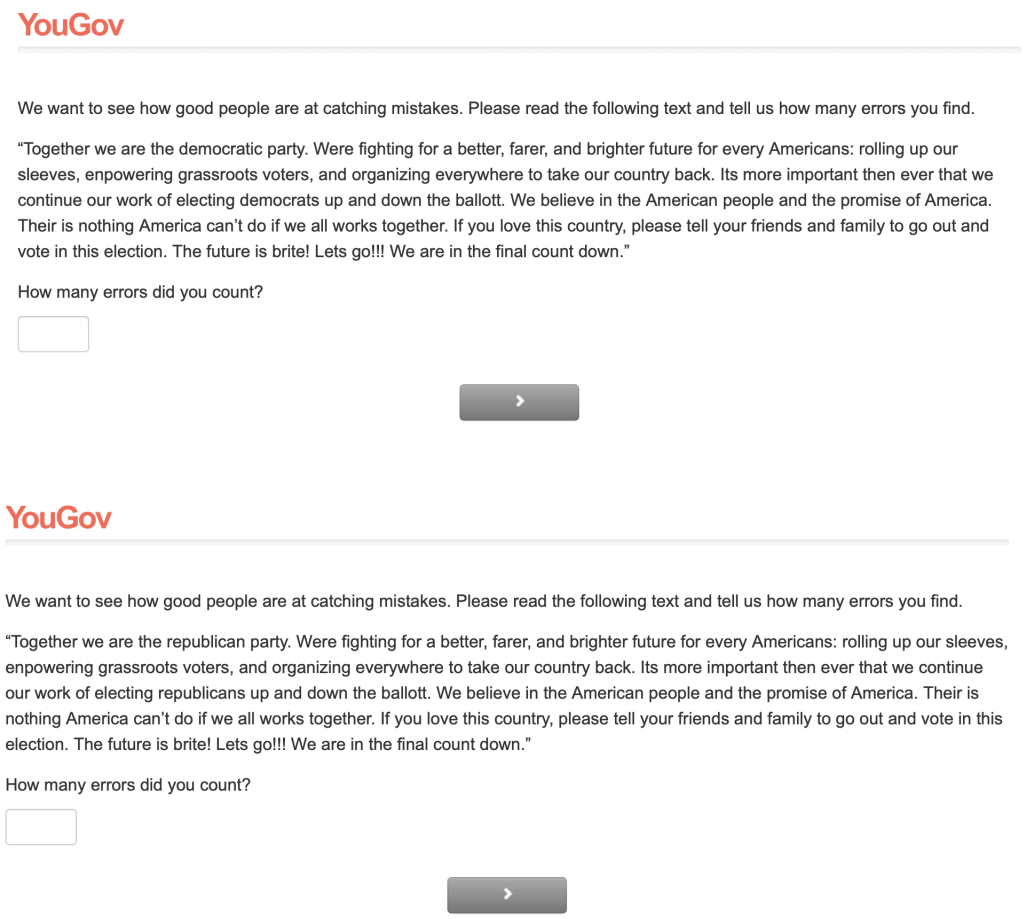
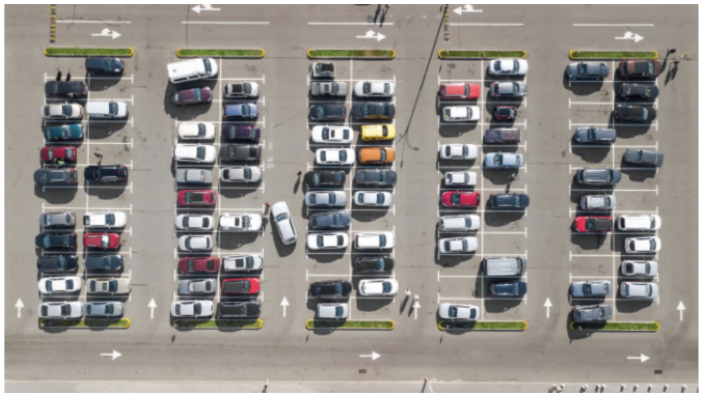


Figure SI 1.2: Parking Lot

YouGov



We want to see how much attention people are paying in answering questions. How many cars would you say are poorly parked in this picture of the parking lot outside a Democratic Party meeting last year?

SI 2 Figures

Figure SI 2.1: Writing Errors (CCES)

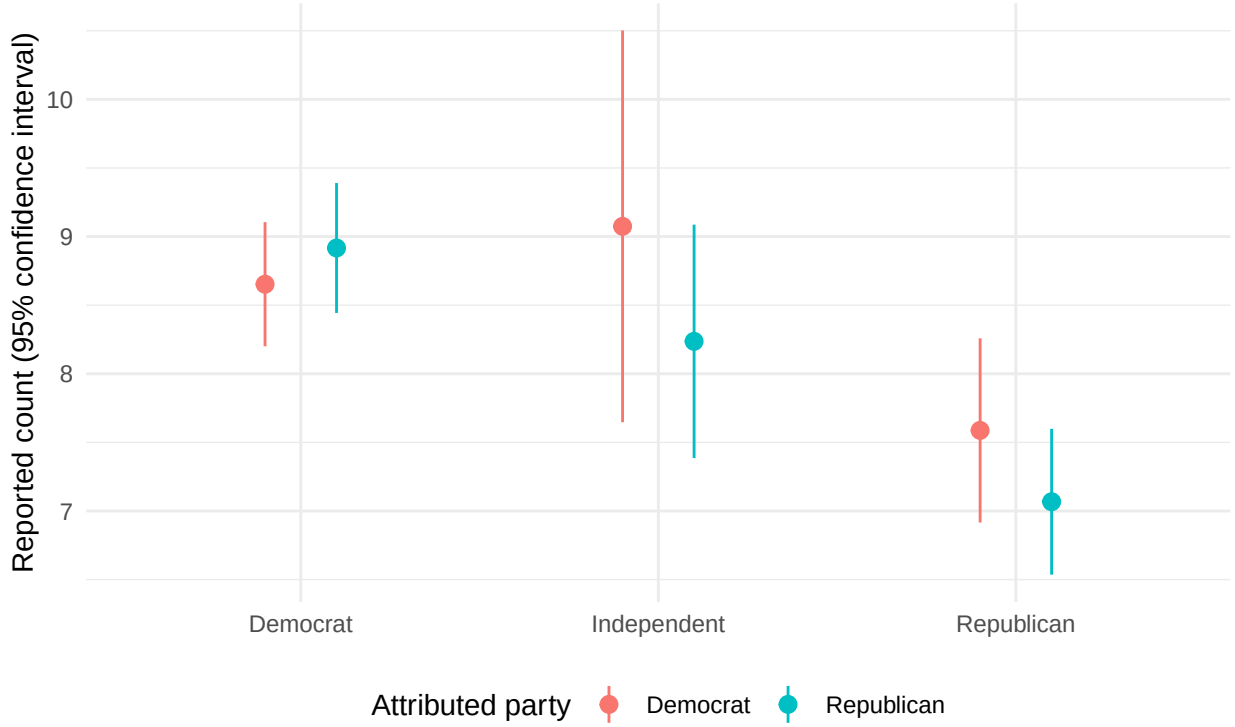


Figure SI 2.2: Writing Errors (Lucid)

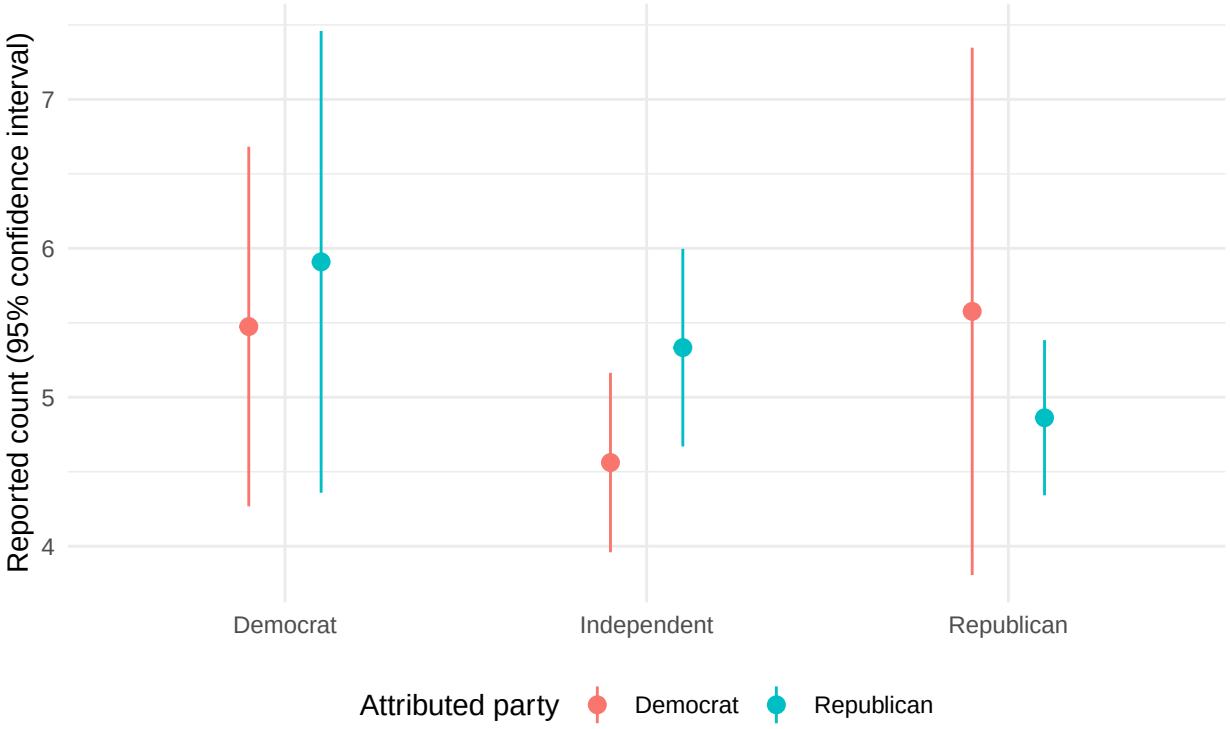


Figure SI 2.3: Poorly Parked Cars (CCES)

